in an age where dissent of any kind may be labelled anti-state or treasonous – such actions on social media cannot simply be dismissed. As another student in Lahore highlighted, social media activism allows '*ordinary people an agency or a voice*' (Student, Female, Lahore). If that voice is perceived to be suppressed, then social media sites such as Facebook definitely provide an avenue for that voice to be heard. However, the extent to which young people even engage in social media debate or discussion varies across individuals, as does their level of political awareness. This political awareness is defined in the following ways: '*Yes [I am politically aware] because of political posts which have been uploaded by someone*' (Student, Male, Lahore); '*Yeah, after all it makes all of us aware of the circumstances all around*' (Student, Female, Sialkot); '*Yes because you can share information with everyone and people do use it on a daily basis*' (Student, Female, Lahore).

The potential that social media has in raising such political awareness cannot be discounted, especially in a context like Pakistan where a lack of political literacy, let alone activism, among the majority of the youth continues to be a problem. However, contrary to such narratives there were others who on further probing provided insights about the limitations of being active online: '*Yes, it makes people aware of others' political views and thus enhances your information*' (Student, Female, Sheikhupura). Others also highlighted these limitations in offline activism in their narratives: '*Because only liking any post doesn't make you politically aware*' (Student, Female, Lahore); '*Facebook does make you politically active. You can change profile pics, take a stand … . I think people can take out their aggression on Facebook and TV but don't come out*' (Focus Group, Private University[12]); '*No, because after letting out steam, they lose all interest and develop a this-is-not-my-problem attitude*' (Student, Female, Karachi); '*No it encourages complacency by making people believe they are politically active by simply posting articles rather than initiating in any tangible change*' (Student, Male, Karachi); '*Because after tweeting, people believe they have done their part in showing their disapproval but they don't take any actions or deduce practical solutions. It's a ranting place*' (Student, Female, Karachi). These responses reflect the 'slacktivism' hypothesis, where there is a danger that such online expression will not translate into offline action (Howard et al. 2016, p. 56).

In response to the participants who believe that online activism is nothing more than a place to rant, where people remain complacent or develop a '*this-is-not-my-problem attitude*', the response of the security state to online activism may seem quite exaggerated. However, it is the potential that the